

CITY

THE OTTAWA CITIZEN

From Italy to Canadians with love

An exhibit at the Museum of Civilization features artifacts from Italian immigrants who now call this country home, says **Tony Lofaro.**

Both Italy's rich cultural past and the contributions Italians have made to their adopted home of Canada are amply showcased in Pre-senza, an exhibition that opened yesterday at the Canadian Museum of Civilization.

The exhibit features more than 300 artifacts, including a countertop café-style espresso machine, an intricate wood carving of the Milan Cathedral, an authentic gondola from Venice, a colourful Sicilian wood cart and an old Northland hockey stick belonging to Phil Disposito.

And through videotaped interviews with 80 Italian-Canadians, photographs of Italians at religious feasts and at bocce games, displays of food, fashion and farm products, the exhibit kicks off a 15-month celebration that will include concerts, film festivals, regional cuisine demonstrations and craft-making displays.

"I hope the young Italian-Canadians will understand what we wanted to do in this exhibit: that is to show that the many aspects of the past that their parents brought over to Canada are not only something belonging to an outdated past," said Mauro Peressini, the museum's curator.

He said if young people see the artifacts and listen to stories of immigrant Italians, they will get a better sense of the struggle older Italians experienced when they left their homeland to build roots in a new country.

Several artifacts belong to Italians living in Ottawa — in-

for their homes.

A deeply religious woman, she had plans to enter a convent, but found her calling in the helping the less fortunate in the community. She worked long hours as a real estate broker, Vincenzo, who had suffered three workplace accidents, and she raised three children, Angela, Anthony and Peter.

Salvatore Lamonica left Pinaro, Sicily for Canada in 1954 at the age of 24 after five years as a police officer with the Italian carabinieri.

As a young man in Italy, he used to hang out at the town's forge, working with metal and learning a trade from blacksmiths. In a town with little work and an abundance of able-bodied men, Mr. Lamonica left his hometown to follow his sweetheart, Carolina, who had already settled in Ottawa with her family.

A week after arriving in Canada, he married his fiancée, raised a family and forged a career as a sheet metal worker with an artistic flair, creating sculptures of religious figures, humans and animals from tiny scraps of discarded metal.

"I did not know much about Canada before I came, only that it was a good country," said Mr. Lamonica, 73, sipping an espresso in the kitchen of his Alta Vista-area home.

"I wanted to try it, I was a young boy. I came for a better life than what I had."

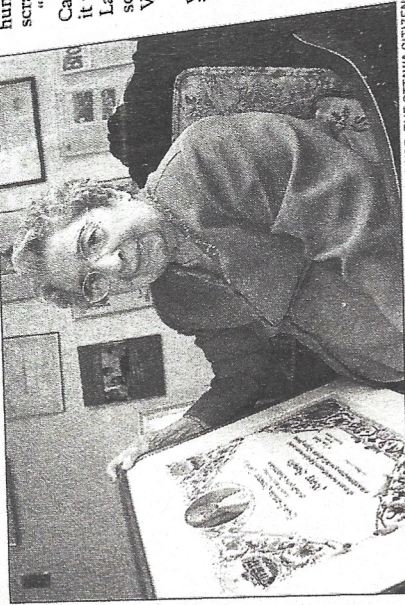
His first impression of Ottawa was that it resembled "a small town in Italy." He remembers the city stretching south as far as Dow's Lake, streetcars on Preston Street, and pockets of Italian immigrants scattered around St. Anthony's Church on Booth Street.

He began working at Ottawa Iron Works, earning 65 cents a hour. In his spare time he collected scraps of metal and created different metal objects. One of his first works was of life-size statue of a former boss at Trudel & MacAdam Iron Works, a company he joined after Ottawa Iron Works shut down.

He has also created a two-metre-by-five-metre metal dinosaur, and metal statues of le-



SIMON HAYTER, THE OTTAWA CITIZEN



ROD MACVOR, THE OTTAWA CITIZEN



PAT MCGRATH, THE OTTAWA CITIZEN

At top, Salvatore Lamonica shows some of the large sculptures he creates out of scrap metal. The sheet metal worker creates sculptures of religious figures, animals and humans. Above left, detail from a cart that is part of the Italian-Canadian exhibition. Above right, Maria Jerullo is one of the contributors to the exhibition and shows one of her many clippings and plaques, including one from the Pope.

country she had adopted as her new home. She was the first female real estate broker in Ottawa and possibly Canada, she helped establish the first prenatal clinic for immigrant women at the Civic Hospital, and as a freelance court interpreter, she helped many Italians attached to her home — that the tireless Ms. Jerullo worked. Yet, she was always scooting around town, either helping Italians purchase a home, solving their legal problems or working with the priests at St. Anthony's Church to welcome new immigrants to Ottawa.

Italian community and in a long distinguished business career she won many awards. A champion of women's rights, Ms. Jerullo felt strongly that women's work and place in society should be on equal footing with men's. She also fought for the rights of homeowners, and

a pig made from scrap metal by Salvatore Lamonica and a collection of dolls made by Maria Saracino, a doll collector.

Ms. Jerullo was eight years old when she sailed to Canada with her mother, uncle and grandmother from GeroCarne in the southern province of Calabria.